

the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are aged 65 and over has increased by 1.5 million, and the number of people aged 75 and over has increased by 1.2 million (Office for National Statistics 2000). The number of people aged 65 and over is projected to increase to 6.5 million by 2020, and the number of people aged 75 and over to 4.5 million (Office for National Statistics 2000).

There is a growing awareness of the need to address the health and social care needs of older people. The Department of Health (2000) has published a strategy for older people, which sets out the government's commitment to improve the health and social care of older people. The strategy is based on three main principles: (1) to improve the health and social care of older people; (2) to ensure that older people are able to live independently; and (3) to ensure that older people are able to participate in society. The strategy is based on the following key objectives:

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